

Learning Programme Design

Needs Analysis to a 10-Week Learning Pathway

Needs analysis · Diagnostic assessment · Learning objectives · Programme design · Assessment and feedback

Adapted from original programme-design work completed as part of the Cambridge DELTA diploma.

Programme at a glance

AUDIENCE	DURATION	PRIMARY NEED	DESIGN BASIS
10 learners aged 16-17	10 x 2-hour sessions	FCE Use of English performance	Needs analysis + diagnostic data

Programme overview

The programme was designed as a focused ten-week learning pathway running alongside the learners' existing examination course. Its purpose was to strengthen performance in the FCE Use of English paper while maintaining an active, communicative learning experience rather than relying on repeated test practice alone.

The learning need

The learner group was cohesive and motivated, but the needs analysis showed that Use of English was perceived as the weakest examination area. Diagnostic testing confirmed substantial gaps in task performance, particularly where learners needed to generate or transform language rather than select from given options.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Use evidence from learner needs and diagnostic performance to decide what to teach, how to sequence it, and how much guided practice and feedback learners require.

The portfolio version omits third-party exam questions and coursebook extracts and focuses on the programme-design decisions and evidence.

01 · ANALYSIS

Needs analysis and diagnostic findings

I combined multiple evidence sources rather than relying on a single questionnaire or test. This helped distinguish learners' stated preferences from demonstrated performance needs.

Evidence sources

LEARNER QUESTIONNAIRE Goals, perceived strengths, difficulties and interaction preferences	PRIOR PERFORMANCE Previous course results and examination experience
TEACHER EVIDENCE Previous-teacher comments plus direct classroom observation	DIAGNOSTIC TEST Authentic FCE Use of English practice under test conditions

Key findings

80% were primarily studying for future study or career opportunities.	80% preferred speaking/communicative work or a mixture of communication and practice.
43.6% was the overall class average on the diagnostic Use of English test.	61% average on Part 1, the strongest diagnostic section.
38-39% average range across the other three diagnostic sections.	Priority gaps included phrasal verbs, tense forms, word forms, prepositions and linking words.

What the evidence changed

Strategy training Make task instructions, context, prediction and answer discrimination explicit rather than assuming learners already knew how to approach the paper.	Language priorities Concentrate on word forms, tense and verb patterns, prepositions, collocations and other recurring problem areas identified in the data.	Delivery approach Balance exam-focused practice with pair/group work, learner-generated tasks and communicative activities to sustain motivation and participation.
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02 • DESIGN

Learning objectives and 10-week pathway

The programme objectives translated the analysis into observable areas of learner performance. The pathway then revisited core strategies and language across progressively more demanding practice.

Learning objectives

- Understand the examination format, rubrics and marking expectations.
- Use context, prediction and logical discrimination to approach tasks more systematically.
- Strengthen key grammatical and lexical forms within the examination context.
- Break complex tasks into clear stages and apply strategies under timed conditions.

10-week learning pathway

WEEK	FOCUS	LEARNING EMPHASIS
1	Foundations	Diagnostic-linked discussion, exam format, task strategy foundations, Parts 1-2.
2	Multiple-choice cloze	Context, answer discrimination, confusing words, timed Part 1 practice.
3	Collocation + open cloze	Verb/noun collocations, communicative practice, introduction to Part 2.
4	Part 2 consolidation	Prepositional phrasal verbs, learner-generated practice and exam application.
5	Word formation	Introduce Parts 3-4, word-form analysis, personalised and collaborative practice.
6	Word-form accuracy	Adjectives and word classes, timed Part 1 practice, collaborative review.
7	Sentence transformation	Verb forms and tense review, Part 4 strategy and guided practice.
8	Integrated exam practice	Common errors, Parts 1/3/4 practice, explanation and peer justification.
9	Full practice test	Timed full-paper practice followed by collaborative language review.
10	Feedback + next steps	Practice-test feedback, learner reflection and preparation planning.

DESIGN LOGIC

Move from awareness and guided strategy use to increasingly independent, timed application. Revisit language and strategies across the programme rather than treating them as one-off topics.

03 · ASSESSMENT & EVALUATION

Assessment, feedback and programme evaluation

Assessment was embedded throughout the pathway so that teaching decisions could respond to learner performance rather than waiting until the end of the course.

Assessment cycle



How progress was checked

- Diagnostic testing established a starting point and highlighted task-specific weaknesses.
- Peer checking, teacher feedback and homework review provided frequent formative feedback.
- Timed examination tasks tested whether strategies could be applied under realistic conditions.
- A full practice Use of English test in Week 9 provided an integrated performance check.
- Week 10 combined detailed test feedback with learner reflection on what had changed since the beginning of the programme.

What this portfolio artefact demonstrates

Learning needs analysis Combining self-report, historical evidence, observation and diagnostic performance.	Evidence-based design Turning findings into clear learning priorities and programme decisions.
Learning-objective design Connecting desired learner performance to course content and practice.	Curriculum sequencing Building a coherent pathway from foundations to integrated performance.
Active learning Using collaborative, communicative and learner-generated practice alongside technical input.	Assessment & feedback Embedding diagnostic, formative and summative-style checkpoints throughout the programme.

Source note

Retrospective portfolio presentation adapted from original Cambridge DELTA extended-assignment and course-plan work completed in 2013-2014. Learner identities are not included. Third-party examination questions and published coursebook extracts have been omitted.